

RAVENSTEIN'S LAWS OF MIGRATION

E.G. Ravenstein wrote three articles on migration over 100 years ago, and his writings have proven to be highly influential in subsequent research on migration issues. These articles identified eleven "laws", more correctly described as generalizations, and were based on information contained in the British censuses of 1871 and 1881.

These laws apply to VOLUNTARY Migration – people who move by choice.

1. The majority of migrants travel only a short distance. → they move to a new home across town.
2. Migration proceeds step-by-step. (from rural/farm to small village, to a town, then to a city)
3. Migrants moving a long distance generally go to one of the great centers of commerce or industry – they move to a large city with lots of job opportunities.
More likely to move to New York City, NY, than to Taylor, TX.
4. Each current of migration produces a compensating counter-current.
– Small stream moves back. Ex. 1900-1914, 13 mil. moved from Europe
est. 4 mil return
5. The natives of towns are less migratory than those of rural areas.
reflects rural-to-urban migration
6. Females are more migratory than males within their country of birth, but males more frequently move internationally. – young women move to cities to work in factories or as domestic help until they marry.
7. Most migrants are adults. Families with children rarely migrate out of their country of birth.
If they do, it tends to be for economic opportunity
8. Large towns grow more by migration than through natural increase
Increased urbanization → fewer opportunities in rural areas
9. Migration increases in volume as industries and commerce develop and transport improves.
more economic pull, greater infrastructure makes it easier to get there
10. The major direction of migration is from agricultural areas to centers of industry and commerce.
→ in MDCs, this is no longer true → urban to urban
→ in LDCs, still true today

- ★ (11) The major causes of migration are economic.
Still true today. Primary push = lack of economic opportunity
primary pull = greater economic opportunity

These eleven statements have been modified, but not disproven by subsequent researchers. They are somewhat time-specific, but they are generally valid even today. The principal limitations are the exclusion of reference to various forms of forced (as opposed to voluntary) migrations and the failure to account for the current exodus from large cities.

RAVENSTEIN'S LAWS OF MIGRATION: AS APPLIED TO THE UNITED STATES

In addition to long-distance migrations between regions, many other forms of migration are occurring within the United States. The following statements reflect the findings of a Census Bureau study of major movements in the late 1900s:

1. The majority of migrants move a short distance. Slightly over 2/3 of all migrants only move within their same community. → still true today

2. Migrants from towns and small cities tend to move to larger urban places.

→ re-inforces Ravenstein's laws

3. The countercurrent from large cities to rural places, which was observed in the 1970s has decreased in importance. Reverse of sub-urbanization,

resurgence of cities as desirable place to live for some groups

4. Males are more likely to migrate than females, although the difference is very small.

→ Counter to Ravenstein, but possibly explained by economic development.

5. Young adults are the most mobile group. For example, people in their 20s tend to move much more than people in their 40s. Ravenstein #7. Single adults most likely to move, especially into urban areas.

6. A person with a college degree is more likely to move than one with less schooling.

Why do you think this would be? Edu. level not addressed by Ravenstein.

7. Hispanics are more likely to migrate than whites or blacks.

Why? → follow the work. Black groups more deeply rooted in community, or generational poverty makes it more difficult to move.

8. The mobility varies from region to region. In 1983-84, 22% of all persons in the "West"

moved, but in the Northeast, only 12% were migrants.

Why? What would cause the difference btw regions? more about this in urban unit
-immigrant populations?
-greater variety of economic opportunity?
-younger populations?

Something to think about...

Many moves are associated with certain phases of life. What events in your life or your family situation would be likely to prompt a move of some type?